

Introduction

This reflection will analyse the key issues within educational experiences that individuals with autism encounter. Individuals with autism have three main difficulties which are with communication, social interaction and behaviour (Fast Company, 2017; Silberman, 2001; Autism Queensland, 2016; De Luca 2012). These individuals are affected in areas such as having sensory issues, bullying in school, anxiety, stigma, late diagnosis, lack of knowledge of autism of the educators around them and barriers in inclusive education. It will analyse contemporary pedagogy and practices that extended, reinforced and challenged my beliefs. Areas to be discussed are inclusive education, personalised education, flexible classrooms, changing the curriculum, technology, differentiation, focusing on individuals' interests, therapies, community and carers. From my perspective as a teacher, it is vital for individuals with autism to be included within education using strategies collectively. Moreover, the curriculum needs to be altered to ensure that it is relevant for this cohort of people too.

Key Issues and practices implemented

Social interaction and communication

A key issue many individuals with autism face is limitations in the area of communication and social interactions such as making friends (Amaze, 2017; Australian Family Physician, 2015; Erinclem, 2013; Gray, 2014; Hannah, 2012; Healy, 2013; Nall, 2015; Raising Children, (n.d); The Atlantic, 2014). Girton Grammar School (2016) were able to introduce a sports program that allowed children with autism to make friends with children from different schools. This therefore is placing less onus on the skill of the sport and changes the focus to benefit children with this deficit. There are also therapies available to help with social communication (Howcast, 2014). Many individuals have issues with speech thus AAC devices aid individuals in this area (Ronski, 2015).

Behavioural issues

Behaviour challenges can occur in individuals with autism and these can often arise such as if a routine or schedule is altered (Silberman, 2001; Cheak-Zamora, 2015). Behaviour therapy APA is recommended to combat poor behaviour (Carpenter, 2015; Nall, 2018).

Sensory issues

Another issue for individuals with autism is their sensory issues (Healy, 2013; De Luca 2012; Legge, 2016; Reallookautism, 2011). A child could be given headphones to reduce the surrounding noise which could help with example with anxiety (Ikuta, 2016, Hannah, 2012). It is important therefore that their sensory needs are met via for example a sensory room that two schools introduced in Australia (Edutopia, 2017; Davis and Dennis Films, 2015).

A notion that challenged me initially was I did not realise teachers were not confident supporting children with autism in their classrooms. After researching these areas, I was able to determine that many teachers do not have the training to be confident to ensure individuals with autism are included within their classroom. In addition to this, many fail to identify symptoms of autism (Healy, 2013; McMurray, 2016; Sanahuja, 2016; Lakkala, 2016; Monsen, 2014). Educators need the support of Allied Health professionals such as Speech Therapist and Occupational Therapist to be able to suggest strategies for them to implement within their classrooms (Howcast, 2014; Tomcheck, 2017).

Mental health conditions:

Many children with autism experience anxiety and have a negative self -evaluation of themselves (Hannah, 2012). Individuals need to be given options such as being advised to see a General Practitioner or counsellor or given anti-anxiety medication or access to behavioural programs (Australian Family Physician, 2015; The National Autistic Society, 2016; Carpenter,

2015; Autism Speaks, 2017). They can be advised to peruse websites for advice and support on mental health issue (Bonnello, 2015; The National Autistic Society, 2016).

Late diagnosis

It is important that a diagnosis of autism is made early on in an individual's life (Legge 2016; Russel, Golding, Norwich, Emond, and Steer, 2012; Rydzewska, 2012; Sarris, 2015). This will enable a child to have the necessary support needs and interventions to be put into place immediately at school and at home. The definition of autism has also changed over several decades which has affected whether they receive support and whether their autism is diagnosed (Silberman, 2001; Voices from Spectrum, 2017; Rydzewska, 2012; Bonnello, 2015).

Contemporary pedagogy and practices:

Education programs in schools

Interventions are recommended for individuals with autism (Ronski, 2015, Guldberg, 2010; Kasari, 2016; Zenko, 2014; Carpenter, 2015). School plays a vital role in ensuring that individuals become equipped as they leave school organized for adulthood (Wilczynski, 2013). It is essential that education programs are introduced for individuals with disabilities this extended my beliefs as I did not realise there were so many available programs (Wilczynski, 2013; PBSO, 2016; Rulerapproach, 2011; Trojan Live, 2017).

Individual Education Plans

As a teacher, I am aware I must support the needs of the children in my class by implementing resources such as individual personalised education plans (Rydzewska, 2012 ; Gray, 2014 ; Ambitious about autism, 2012; Zenko, 2014, Ronski, 2015; Guldberg, 2010; Sarris, 2015 ; Kasari, 2016; Trembath, 2015). These plans allow educators to consider a child's

specific needs and regularly set targets and goals. This extended my belief as I was aware of IEPS.

Inclusive education

It must be considered that educational experiences are important to all children via the inclusive education concept. This education pedagogy is integrated to ensure that individuals with special educational needs feel cherished, included and wanted which extended my beliefs (Monsen, 2014; Arnaiz, 2016; McMurray, 2016; Edutopia, 2017; Lakkala, 2016; Raising Children Network, 2017). The barrier to inclusion is that many schools feel that they are not appropriately equipped to cater for individuals with autism (McMurray, 2016; Sanahuja, 2016; The Strait Times, 2017, Arnaiz, 2016).

Personalised learning

Personalised learning is another contemporary practice and it is vital within a classroom to ensure that a child's needs are met (Edutopia, 2017; Totsmart Education, 2016; Nellie May, 2015; Hawker Brownlow Education, 2015). It ensures that the work set by the teachers appeals and is engaging to the individual and therefore is subjective. Children need to be actively involved in their learning and more practical methods used (Arnaiz, 2016; Donahoo, 2013). Educators need to ensure that children are engaged in their learning by merging their strengths and interests into their learning (DIY, 2016; Edutopia, 2017; Donahoo, 2013; VOA, 2016; Bonello, 2015; Post 21 Club, 2013; Forbes 2017; Silberman 2001).

Differentiation

It is important that differentiation occurs within a classroom to ensure that the work is pitched at the appropriate level for the child and not too difficult (Hawker Brownlow Education 2013).

Curriculum

It is important that the curriculum within a school is adapted and modified to ensure that it is relevant and appropriate for the individuals it reaches. The curriculum should be delivered in an alternative method and alter the style of teaching to ensure individuals achieves success (Arnaiz 2016). Extra- curricular activities are thus important, and these should be made available in schools to all individuals and to move away from following a strict, rigid curriculum (McMurray, 2016; Arnaiz, 2016). It is important for schools to have flexible and adaptable classrooms including physical space and seating positions to suit the needs of children based upon the content they are learning and whether they need to sit independently or in groups (Edutopia, 2017; Edutopia, 2015). Educators need to use more technology and to ensure that education practice is hence current and up to date to fit with today's children (DIY, 2016; Wired 2011; Australian Broadcasting Corporation, 2013; Ronski, 2015).

Therapies

There are many types of contemporary therapy that are available today for individuals with autism to access. We need to introduce therapies and try new methods such as animal game and play therapy (Howscast, 2004, O'Haire, 2013, New Scientist, 2016; Australian Broadcasting Corporation, 2016; Tomcheck, 2017; Nall 2018). I believe that a collection of these need to be tried on children with autism by their educators. Cognitive behaviour therapy could be used which involves discussing feelings, reactions and relaxation strategies. This can aid a child in making friends (Raising Children Network, 2017).

Carers

Parents and carers play an important support role in the lives of individuals with autism (Autism Spectrum Australia, 2012; Raising Children Network, 2017; Voices from Spectrum, 2012). Parents are a child's best resource and they should be involved collaboratively in their

children's education (Billington, 2000; McMurray, 2016; Legge, 2016; Raising Children Network, 2017). There are many barriers such as access to the right school can be a problem for parents, which challenges my knowledge as I did not realise this would be an issue (Australian Broadcasting Corporation, 2014, The Strait Times, 2017). Carers need support from services to help them to cope within themselves through counselling, carer support groups and from GP referrals (Romski, 2015; Raising Children Network, 2017).

In conclusion, this essay has discussed key issues within educational experiences and the strategies that combat these. It has analysed the area of communication, social interaction and behaviour ((Fast Company, 2017; Silberman, 2001; Autism Queensland, 2016; De Luca 2012). It has also discussed areas such as sensory issues, anxiety, stigma, late diagnosis, lack of knowledge of autism of the educators around them and barriers in inclusive education. It is important that children's perspective are obtained (Healy 2013; Brain highways 2015). The community need to play a larger part in ensuring that individuals with autism are supported (Arnaiz,2016; Lakkala, 2016, The National Autistic Society 2015). I was unaware that many different approaches were available to those with autism and this has extended my beliefs that there is support available. The notions of inclusive education, personalised education, flexible classrooms, changing the curriculum, technology, differentiation, focusing on individuals' interests, therapies, community and carers have all extended my knowledge in this area and will be invaluable when I place these into practice within my classroom. Inclusive education remains an important pedagogy that needs to continue to be enforced vigorously using the mentioned strategies collectively to ensure individuals with autism benefit in an educational setting. I believe the curriculum must also continue to be developed to follow this concept.

References

Amaze. (2017). *Adults on the spectrum*. Available: <http://www.amaze.org.au/discover/about-autism-spectrum-disorder/adults-on-the-spectrum/>

Ambitious about autism. (2012). *Towards independence – A young person with autism on work experience*. Available: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VnPPbAWzUuU>

Arnaiz, P. Escarbajal, A., Guirao, J.M, & Martinez, R. (2016). Building Inclusive Processes for School Improvement: A case study. *Journal of Research in Special Educational Needs*, 16290-294.

Australian Broadcasting Corporation. (2016). *‘Serious games’ for children with autism could provide new therapy options*. Available: <http://www.abc.net.au/news/health/2016-08-18/serious-games-could-provide-new-therapies-for-kids-with-autism/7700380>

Autism Queensland. (2016). *Living with autism – Ky’s story*. Available: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=p4J59GY8DR4>

Autism Speaks. (2017). *Autism’s associated medical conditions*. Available: <https://www.autismspeaks.org/what-autism/treatment/treatment-associated-medical-conditions>

Billington, T. (2000). Autism: Working with parents, and discourses in experience, expertise and learning. *Educational Psychology in Practice*, 16(1), 59-68.

Bonnello, C. (2015). Growing Up Autistic: 10 tips for teenagers with Asperger syndrome or ‘mild’ autism. Available: <http://autisticnotweird.com/growing-up-autistic-advice-for-teenagers-with-asperger-syndrome-or-mild-autism/>

Brainhighways. (2015). *Dear Teacher: Heartfelt advice for teachers from students*. Available: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lTMLzXzgB_s

Carpenter, S. (2015). *Life after autism*. http://www.slate.com/articles/health_and_science/medical_examiner/2015/09/is_autism_permanent_some_children_diagnosed_with_autism_seem_to_grow_out.html

Cheak-Zamora, N. (2015). Transitions are scary for our kids, and they're scary for us-: Family member and youth perspectives on the challenges of transitioning to adulthood with autism. *Journal of Applied Research in Intellectual Disabilities*, 28(6), 548-560. <https://lesa.on.worldcat.org/oclc/6906444772>

Davis and Dennis Films. (2015). *Multi-sensory Documentary*. Available: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BiX7y1wgU_E

De Luca 2012 <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Ojf2n7VwOJk>

Donahoo, D. (2013). *Project-Based learning, yes PLIESE*. Available: <https://www.wired.com/2010/11/project-based-learning-yes-pliese/>

Edutopia. (2017). *Flexible classrooms: Making space for personalised learning*. Available: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jQkL5efkViw>

Edutopia (2017). *The sensory room: helping students with autism focus and learn*. Available: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=T9j6rQ4rtQY>

Edutopia (2017). *Thinkering studio - supporting self directed learning*. Available: <https://www.edutopia.org/article/thinkering-studio-supporting-self-directed-learning>

Erinclem (2013). *What Autism Feels Like (School Version)*. Available: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GTT1KldAQbo>

FastCompany. (2017). *Teaching autistic children with robots*. Available: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2Ko8O-4sINw>

Girton Grammar School. (2016). *A sporting change program*. Available: <https://www.facebook.com/GirtonGrammarSchoolBendigo/videos/1502058539828841/>

Gray. K.M (2014). Adult outcomes in autism: Community inclusion and living skills. *Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders*, 44(12), 3006-15. doi:10.1007/s10803-014-2159-x <https://lesa.on.worldcat.org/oclc/5693986317>

Guldborg, K. (2010). Educating children on the autism spectrum/ preconditions for inclusion and notions of 'best autism practice' in the early years. *British Journal Of Special Education*, 37(4). <https://lesa.on.worldcat.org/oclc/694977581>

Hannah, E. e., & Topping, K. J. (2012). Anxiety Levels in Students with Autism Spectrum Disorder Making the Transition from Primary to Secondary School. *Education & Training In Autism & Developmental Disabilities*, 47(2), 198-209. <https://lesa.on.worldcat.org/oclc/802914017>

Hawker Brownlow Education (2013). *Differentiation and the brain: a discussion with Carol-Ann Tomlinson*. Available: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mLzCqoPFxRw>

DIY.com (2016). *Awesome skills for awesome kids*. Available: <https://diy.org>

Healy, S., Msetfi, R and Gallagher, S. (2013). 'Happy and a bit nervous': The experiences of children with autism in physical education. *British Journal of Learning Disabilities*, 41(3), 222-228. doi:10.1111/bld.12053 <https://lesa.on.worldcat.org/oclc/857036317>

Howcast. (2014). *10 types of Autism Therapy*. Available: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=JeMycRm-H6M>

Ikuta, N., Iwanaga, R., Tokunaga, A., Nakane, H., Tanaka, K., & Tanaka, G. (2016).

Effectiveness of earmuffs and noise-cancelling headphones for coping with hyper-reactivity to auditory stimuli in children with autism spectrum disorder: A preliminary study. *Hong Kong Journal of Occupational Therapy*, 28(1), 24-32. doi:10.1016/j.hkjot.2016.09.001

Kasari (2016) *Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry*

Lakkala, S. Uusiautti, S. & Maata, K. (2016). How to make the neighbourhood school a school for all?: Finnish teachers' perceptions of educational reform aiming towards inclusion. *Journal of Research in Special Educational Needs*, 16(1), 46-56.

Legge, K. (2016) *The autism explosion in Australian*

Schools. Available: <http://www.theaustralian.com.au/life/weekend-australian-magazine/the-autism-explosion-in-australian-schools/news-story/7b0b56a5f5c9f6525dedffc8d7f6e5d8>

McMurray, S. & Thompson, R. (2016). Inclusion, Curriculum and the Rights of the Child. *Journal of Research in Special Educational Needs*, 16634-639

Monsen, J. J., Ewing, D. L., & Kwoka, M. (2014). Teachers' attitudes towards inclusion, perceived adequacy of support and classroom learning environment. *Learning Environments Research*, 17(1), 113-126. doi:http://dx.doi.org.ezproxy.laureate.net.au/10.1007/s10984-013-9144-8

NellieMayEdFdn (2015). *Transformation*. Available: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=e6ieXLVCss4>

Australian Broadcasting Corporation. (2013). *Educating GenWifi*. Available: <http://www.abc.net.au/radionational/programs/breakfast/educating-gen-wifi/4492686>

New Scientist. (2016). *How Minecraft is helping children with autism make new friends*. Available: <https://www.newscientist.com/article/mg23030713-100-how-is-helping-children-with-autism-make-new-friends/>

O'haire, M.,E. (2013). Animal-assisted intervention for autism spectrum disorder: A systematic literature review. *Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders*, 43 (7), 1606-22. doi:<http://dx.doi.org.ezproxy.laureate.net.au/10.1007/s10803-012-1707-5> <https://leson.worldcat.org/oclc/848301289>

PBSO News update. (2016). Giving adults with autism the skills to build independent lives. Available: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BT1GWb2BoRE>

Post21Club. (2013). Autism post 21 – a new set of challenges. Available: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-Q5LCRdQEBI>

Raising children network. (2017) *School support: children with disability*. Available: http://raisingchildren.net.au/articles/disability_school_support.html

Reallookautism. (2011). *Anxiety in school: Real look autism episode 1*. Available: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=riS53sCbLfo>

Romski, M., Sevcik, R. A., Barton-Hulsey, A., & Whitmore, A. S. (2015). Early Intervention and AAC: What a Difference 30 Years Makes. *AAC: Augmentative & Alternative Communication*, 31(3), 181-202. doi:10.3109/07434618.2015.1064163 <https://leson.worldcat.org/oclc/5879233693>

Rulerapproach. (2011). *Meta-Moments and The RULER Approach to social and emotional learning*. Available: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yKXLEJqxUxw>

Russell, G., Golding, J., Norwich, B., Emond, A., Ford, T., & Steer, C. (2012). Social and behavioural outcomes in children diagnosed with autism spectrum disorders: a longitudinal cohort study. *Journal Of Child Psychology And Psychiatry, And Allied Disciplines*, 53(7), 735-744. doi:10.1111/j.1469-7610.2011.02490.x<https://lesa.on.worldcat.org/oclc/795246108>

Rydzewska, E. (2012). Destination unknown? transition to adulthood for people with autism spectrum disorders. *British Journal of Special Education*, 39(2), 87-93. <https://lesa.on.worldcat.org/oclc/802920727>

Sanahuja-Gavalda, J.M., Olmos-Rueda, P., & Moron-Velasco, M. (2016). Collaborative Support for Inclusion. *Journal of Research in Special Educational Needs*, 16303-307

The National Autistic Society. (2015). *How teachers can support children with autism*. Available: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Fv66Q-MUxqc>

Sarris, M. (2015). *What will happen when the school bus stops coming?* Available: <https://iancommunity.org/ssc/transition-adulthood-autism-stories>

Silberman, S. (2001). *The geek syndrome*. Available: <https://www.wired.com/2001/12/aspergers/>

Specialisterne Australia. (2016). *SAP Autism at work*. Available: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1zSCcCpCtdQ>

The Straits Times. (2017). 8-year-old boy with autism finally gets to go to school. Available: <http://www.straitstimes.com/singapore/education/a-place-in-school-for-nabil-at-last>

Trembath, D. (2015). *Children with autism aren't necessarily visual learners*. Available: <http://theconversation.com/children-with-autism-arent-necessarily-visual-learners-42758?sa=pg2&sq=autism&sr=10>

Tomchek, S., Koenig, K. P., Arbesman, M., & Lieberman, D. (2017). Occupational therapy interventions for adolescents with autism spectrum disorder. *The American Journal of Occupational Therapy*, 71 (1), 1-3.

doi:<http://dx.doi.org.ezproxy.laureate.net.au/10.5014/ajot.2017.711003>

TotSmart Education (2016). *Zuckerberg shares the importance of personalised learning*. Available: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9ELhxbYISE>

TrojanLive. (2017). *The Autism Story*. Available: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Jx-RI0tRY2E>

VOA Learning English. (2016). *Exceptional Minds: The Creative Power of Young Adults on the Autism Spectrum*. Available: <https://learningenglish.voanews.com/a/3528665.html>

Wilczynski, S. (2013). Improving employment outcomes among adolescents and adults on the autism spectrum. *Psychology in the Schools*, 50(9), 876-887. <https://lesa.on.worldcat.org/oclc/5618234632>

Wired. (2011). *Ipads are not a miracle for children with autism*. Available: <https://www.wired.com/2011/03/ipads-are-not-a-miracle-for-autism-geekdad-opinion/>
